



On the bright side: This season, Telugu Titans have seen a young bunch, under the able leadership of vice-captain Vijay Malik (centre), give an encouraging account of themselves.

the fan base For us, drawing local talent and forming partnerships with local establishments for tournaments or scouting exercises are one way to fill that gap without the luxury of hosting it ourselves," he says.

Academies are another route into the heart of the market. "Anupam Goswami, the league commissioner, once conducted a workshop with all franchises where he took us to the UK to a few football academies to study how youth setups work there. It helped give these ideas in our minds some realistic shape and a glimpse into what some of the ground-level challenges could be too," says Kandpal.

« When we are not delivering, then the excitement or visibility drops, leading to a significant revenue decline. That's not a sustainable path for any organisation – Trinadh Reddy, CEO, Telugu Titans »

Star dynamics

Few understand the power of fan bases like Telugu Titans do. The franchise and its fans have learned one of the harshest lessons of the sporting market: a single player, however big a star they may be, cannot guarantee championship silverware.

The Titans have had the choicest picks over the years and a loyal base that unconditionally backed them through thick and thin. Chaudhari, Siddharth, and Pawan have all donned the Titans yellow, but a title is yet to come. With Chaudhari in the mix, they came close, making the playoffs. But since then, the Titans have largely languished in the depths of the table's bottom half.

Siddharth, their once-imperious raider, faded away under the pressure of carrying the team on his shoulders. Injury troubles with Pawan were an issue last time and this time too. But in 2024, the Titans have seen a young bunch, under the able leadership of vice-captain Vijay Malik, give an encouraging account of themselves. The side is currently placed second with a solid chance of making the playoffs once more.

"Having a star player in the team brings many advantages. Primarily, they have the ability to turn the table at the right moment, and that too single-handedly. They also nurture, shape and elevate the overall performance of the team. So if the captain, the superstar, does well, there will definitely be an impact on the overall performance of the team and on the brand itself," says Titans CEO Trinadh Reddy, standing by the franchise's decisions to keep pursuing these one-man armies to bolster his squad season after season. "There is pressure, but that's what separates the players from the stars."

A separate window

Another crucial aspect of stability for fans, along with long-standing stars and a consistent brand of play, is a marked window for the league. The IPL has a set window in the year. The Indian Super League (ISL), Indian football's top tier, also has a marked duration. 'Why not for kabaddi,'

